

1 INT. GUS'S BEDROOM - BED - DAY

1

A boy, GUS (13), is a nest of blond hair poking out from a blanket. He tugs it up until only his eyes are visible.

GUS
(yawning)
Finally...

MOM (O.S.)
(screaming)
GUS! IT'S NOT EVEN TIME TO GO TO
BED!

SMASH CUT TO:

2 EXT. ROADSIDE - DAY

2

BROOKLYN (13) and KAILYN (13) stand over a patch of dirt, screaming, gesturing wildly at the ground.

BROOKLYN
(angry)
It's a pebble, Kailyn! A normal,
gray pebble!

KAILYN
(disagreeing)
It is clearly a very small rock!
There is a
geological difference!

BROOKLYN
(with condescension)
You know it's a pebble, Kailyn!
Even a kid
like Gus would know that!

Kailyn holds the pebble an inch from Brooklyn's nose.

KAILYN
It. Is. A very small rock.

BROOKLYN
We're wasting time, let's just go.

Brooklyn turns her back and starts walking down the shoulder of the road. Kailyn huffs, pockets the "rock," and jogs to catch up.

KAILYN
They said 4:00 sharp. If he's not
asleep,
we don't get paid.

BROOKLYN

(yawning)

He's thirteen, Kailyn. He's always tired.

Actually, I am too now that I think about it.

KAILYN

(unsure)

We should hurry. Also this kinda seems wrong.

BROOKLYN

I'm sure it's fine. I mean, accepting secret side jobs from nameless strangers isn't bad!

KAILYN

It really, really is.

BROOKLYN

(animatedly)

One. Thousand. Dollars, Kailyn.

A beat.

KAILYN

...How much is that after tax?

3 EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - LATER

3

Brooklyn and Kailyn turn a corner. Brooklyn squints at a crumpled piece of paper with a handwritten address.

KAILYN

Which one is it?

BROOKLYN

The green one. With a fence.

KAILYN

(pointing)

That one, down there.

They walk.

BROOKLYN

Ok. In and out. We check the vitals, get a DNA sample, deposit the blood, get the Cash App. Easy.

KAILYN

Who uses Cash App?

(MORE)

KAILYN (CONT'D)

Isn't that the one with all the
Craigslist scammers?

BROOKLYN

Let's not think about that.

KAILYN

Right. Very smart, Brooklyn. Is
this even legal?

BROOKLYN

Who cares. I want the Shrek
soundtrack and a Dr. Pepper.

KAILYN

A lot of people care, Brooklyn. A
lot.

A pause.

KAILYN (CONT'D)

...I could get some nice skincare
though.

4 EXT. GUS'S HOUSE - MOMENTS LATER

4

Brooklyn and Kailyn stand at the edge of the driveway,
looking up at the high gables.

KAILYN

You're sure this is it? It looks...
expensive.

BROOKLYN

Rich people have weird side-hustles
too, Kailyn. Come on.

They walk up the concrete path toward the arched brick
entryway. As they pass the garage, Brooklyn glances at the
white doors. Pristine. Not a smudge of grease on them.

5 INT. GUS'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

5

Brooklyn and Kailyn weave through a maze of open cardboard
boxes. Some are filled with kitchen foam. Others are
completely empty. It's been a week.

KAILYN

They haven't even unpacked the
toaster.

She eyes a cardboard box.

KAILYN (CONT'D)

I wonder if anyone would care if I
took a pizza lunchable.

BROOKLYN

(smacking her hand away)

NO. We go in and we get out.

The camera drifts upward -- almost accidentally -- to catch
a small SECURITY CAMERA mounted in the corner of the
ceiling. A tiny red light blinks once. Then back to the
girls as they head downstairs.

6 INT. CEMENT ROOM - CONTINUOUS

6

The walls are raw, gray concrete. No carpet. No wallpaper.
Just the hum of a massive REFRIGERATOR in the corner. On
it, a single Post-it note: STAGE 2.

Next to the fridge, a CIRCUIT BREAKER panel hangs open.
Red-orange spots around the switches.

Brooklyn opens the cabinet beside the fridge. On the inside
of the door, taped carefully, a second Post-it:

STAGE 1 -- COMPLETE.

Brooklyn stares at it.

BROOKLYN

(quietly)

We're Stage 2.

KAILYN

What?

BROOKLYN

Nothing. Come on.

KAILYN

(not letting it go)

Brooklyn.

BROOKLYN

I said nothing.

They stand there. The fridge hums.

KAILYN

(quietly, not joking anymore)

That's a lot of power for a
bedroom.

BROOKLYN
What's Stage 2?

No answer.

In one corner: a shelf stacked with unlabeled binders. In another: a bed, perfectly made. In another: a gaming desk and chair. On the desk, a computer in sleep mode.

7 **INT. DARK ROOM - ???**

7

MARLICE (13) sits with her back to the camera. On a monitor in front of her: a grainy security feed. Two girls moving through a concrete room.

She drags a pen down a long handwritten list. We catch a glimpse -- "confirm temp below 32." "hair sample, pre-event." She crosses something off.

MARLICE
(to herself)
Good. They're in.

She leans back.

MARLICE (CONT'D)
Now we wait.

On the desk beside her, a worn piece of paper, folded and refolded many times. She doesn't look at it. She doesn't need to. She has it memorized.

We catch just enough to read:

Stage 1 -- Dormancy
Stage 2 -- Onset
Stage 3 -- Irreversible

8 **INT. GUS'S BEDROOM - DAY**

8

Gus sleeps. Brooklyn notices a small digital gauge clipped to the bed frame. She opens her mouth. Closes it. Decides not to.

KAILYN
(checking the crumpled paper)
What do they mean by a DNA sample?

BROOKLYN
Cut him open and take something?

KAILYN

No, you dumbbell. Probably just hair.

BROOKLYN

That's probably it.

Close on Gus's hair -- messy, blond, undisturbed.

Brooklyn takes the scissors. Carefully clips a few strands. Gus doesn't move.

BROOKLYN (CONT'D)

And then we write the vitals down.

Kailyn picks up a BLOOD OXIMETER from the table. Slides it onto Gus's pointer finger. Watches the number climb.

Then stop.

Kailyn's face goes very still.

She turns the paper face down. Stares at the wall for a moment. Then slowly turns it back toward Brooklyn.

Brooklyn looks at it.

Neither of them speaks.

Brooklyn picks up the SYRINGE.

A long pause.

She looks at Kailyn. Kailyn looks at her.

POV: the Gatorade bottle. The syringe draws back. A thin dark line rises.

Back to Brooklyn's face.

BROOKLYN

(quietly)

I don't like this.

She doesn't stop.

9

EXT. GUS'S HOUSE - LATER

9

Brooklyn and Kailyn sit on the curb outside. Brooklyn has her phone out. She's refreshing Cash App. The street is quiet.

KAILYN

Anything?

BROOKLYN

No.

A beat.

KAILYN

How long do we wait?

BROOKLYN

Until it comes.

KAILYN

And if it doesn't?

Brooklyn doesn't answer. She refreshes again.

Kailyn reaches into her pocket. Takes out the pebble. Turns it over in her fingers.

BROOKLYN

(not looking up)

It's a pebble.

KAILYN

(quietly)

It's a very small rock.

A DING. Brooklyn's phone lights up.

BROOKLYN

(staring at screen)

...It came.

They look at each other. They should feel relieved. They don't.

KAILYN

(Scared)

How did they know we were there?

10 INT. GUS'S BEDROOM - SAME TIME

10

Gus stirs. Not awake -- just a shift. He pulls the blanket tighter.

He mumbles something into the pillow. Almost inaudible.

GUS

(half-asleep)

...not yet.

11 INT. GUS'S BEDROOM - THE NEXT MORNING**11**

Gus sits up slowly. Presses two fingers to his temple. Looks around the room like it's slightly unfamiliar.

He opens the drawer of his nightstand. Takes out a small NOTEBOOK. Uncaps a pen.

He writes: headache again. slept too long. felt wrong.

He stares at it. Then adds: third time this week.

He closes the notebook. Gets up. Doesn't tell anyone.

12 INT. BROOKLYN'S BEDROOM - 2:13 AM**12**

Brooklyn is in bed, phone screen lighting her face. A half-eaten bowl of cereal on the nightstand. She's still refreshing Cash App even though the money came hours ago.

She opens a browser. Types: "DNA sample blood vitals what does it mean."

Results load. All medical. Clinical trials. Blood draws. Routine testing. Normal. All completely normal.

She almost puts the phone down.

Then she types: "stage 2."

She stares at the screen. We don't see what comes up.

Her face changes.

Her phone BUZZES. Unknown number. She answers.

MARLICE (V.O.)
(low, unhurried, distorted)
You took the sample. You wrote the
numbers down. You deposited the
blood.

Brooklyn sits up.

BROOKLYN
(whispering)
Who is this?

MARLICE (V.O.)
You're already part of it.

BROOKLYN
Part of what? Part of what--

MARLICE (V.O.)

Stage 2.

BROOKLYN

What is Stage 2? What does that--

MARLICE (V.O.)

You can't quit now, Brooklyn.

The line goes dead.

Brooklyn sits in the dark. The cereal goes soggy. She doesn't move for a long time.

She doesn't call Kailyn until morning.

13 INT. KAILYN'S BEDROOM - MORNING

13

Brooklyn is already talking before Kailyn is fully awake.

BROOKLYN

(Hurried, stressed)

Someone called me at 2am and they knew my name and they said we're already part of it and I googled Stage 2 and Kailyn I don't think we should have done this I don't think we should have done any of this--

KAILYN

(sitting up slowly)

Brooklyn.

BROOKLYN

What?

Kailyn reaches under her pillow. Takes out the pebble.

KAILYN

Sit down.

Brooklyn sits. Kailyn turns the rock over in her fingers.

KAILYN (CONT'D)

Tell me everything.

14 EXT. STREET - DAY

14

Brooklyn and Kailyn walk fast, heads down, mid-argument.

BROOKLYN

--so we just don't go back. That's it. We

(MORE)

BROOKLYN (CONT'D)
don't go back, we don't answer,
it's over.

KAILYN
They have our Cash App.

BROOKLYN
So?

KAILYN
So they know who we are.

Brooklyn goes quiet.

They reach a crosswalk and stop. Brooklyn jabs the button repeatedly.

KAILYN (CONT'D)
We have to figure out who sent that
message.
We have to figure out what Stage 2
is. We
have to--

BROOKLYN
We don't have to do anything. We
got paid.
We walk away.

KAILYN
Brooklyn.

BROOKLYN
What?

Kailyn isn't looking at her anymore. She's looking across
the park.

There, on the opposite sidewalk, standing completely still --

MARLICE (13). Watching them. Not hiding it. A worn piece
of paper folded in her hand.

People move.

Marlice doesn't.

BROOKLYN (CONT'D)
(quietly)
Is she--

KAILYN
Yeah.

BROOKLYN

Has she been there the whole--

KAILYN

Yeah.

Marlice turns and walks away. Unhurried. Like she knew they'd see her. Like she wanted them to.

BROOKLYN

(after a long pause)

...We're not walking away, are we.

KAILYN

(pebble in her fist)

No. We're really not.

15 INT. DARK ROOM - ???

15

Marlice sits back down at her desk. Pulls out the worn paper. Smooths it flat.

Stage 1 -- Dormancy

Stage 2 -- Onset

Stage 3 -- Irreversible

She stares at Stage 3 for a long time.

Then she picks up her pen. Doesn't cross anything off this time. Just holds it.

MARLICE

(quietly, to no one)

Not yet, Gus.

She folds the paper back up. Puts it in her pocket.

Gets back to work.

16 EXT. PARK - DAY

16

Brooklyn and Kailyn sit on a bench. Brooklyn's leg is bouncing. Kailyn has the pebble out.

BROOKLYN

If she doesn't show up in ten minutes we leave and we never think about this again.

KAILYN

You've said that four times.

BROOKLYN

I mean it this time.

KAILYN

You said that the last three times too.

Brooklyn opens her mouth. Closes it.

Across the park, GUS sits alone on the grass, notebook open, pen moving fast. He doesn't see them. They don't see him.

KAILYN (CONT'D)

(nodding toward him)

Hey isn't that--

BROOKLYN

Don't.

KAILYN

That's literally Gus.

BROOKLYN

I know that's Gus. Don't look at him.

KAILYN

Why?

BROOKLYN

Because if we look at him I feel weird.

KAILYN

You already feel weird.

BROOKLYN

Weirder.

Kailyn looks at Gus anyway. He's writing something fast, pressing hard into the paper. His hand is shaking slightly.

KAILYN

(quietly)

Brooklyn.

BROOKLYN

I see it.

A beat.

Then Gus stops writing. Sets the pen down. Presses both hands flat against the grass like he needs to feel something solid. His breath is visible even though it isn't cold

enough for that.

BROOKLYN (CONT'D)
(standing up)
Ok that's--

MARLICE (O.S.)
Don't.

They spin around.

MARLICE stands behind the bench. Same stillness as before.
Worn piece of paper folded in her hand. She's watching Gus.

MARLICE (CONT'D)
He just needs a minute. It passes.

BROOKLYN
(stressed, hurring)
What passes? What is happening to
him?

MARLICE
Sit down.

BROOKLYN
I don't want to sit down I want to
know what is happening to that kid
right now--

MARLICE
(calm, firm)
Sit. Down.

Brooklyn sits. Kailyn was already sitting.

Marlice comes around the bench and sits between them. She
unfolds the paper. Smooths it flat on the table.

Stage 1 -- Dormancy
Stage 2 -- Onset
Stage 3 -- Irreversible

KAILYN
(reading)
What does irreversible mean?

MARLICE
It means after Stage 3 he doesn't
come back to this. To normal.
Whatever he's becoming,
that's it. That's all he is.

BROOKLYN
What is he becoming?

Marlice looks at her for the first time like she's deciding something.

MARLICE

I don't know exactly. I just know it started six weeks ago and it's accelerating and if his core temperature drops below 28 degrees Stage 3 begins automatically and there is nothing I can do after that.

BROOKLYN

You're thirteen.

MARLICE

I know.

BROOKLYN

You're literally thirteen years old and you're--

MARLICE

I know, Brooklyn.

Silence. Across the park Gus picks his pen back up. His breath is normal again. He doesn't know they're watching him.

KAILYN

What did you need the blood for.

MARLICE

I'm building a stabilizer. Something that holds him at Stage 2 long enough for his body to regulate. The blood tells me how fast it's moving.

KAILYN

And the hair?

MARLICE

DNA markers. I needed to confirm it was actually Stage 2 and not something else.

BROOKLYN

What would something else be?

MARLICE

(beat)

Something worse.

Brooklyn stares at her.

BROOKLYN

How do you even know any of this?

Marlice folds the paper back up. Puts it in her pocket.

MARLICE

Because it happened to my brother.

Nobody says anything.

MARLICE (CONT'D)

Stage 3 took him eight months ago.
I've been working on the stabilizer
since before that but I didn't
finish in time and I am
not doing that again.

She looks at Gus.

MARLICE (CONT'D)

I need one more thing. From his
house. From the cement room.
There's a vial in the
refrigerator, bottom shelf, blue
cap. I need you to get it tonight.

BROOKLYN

Why can't you do it yourself?

MARLICE

Because his mom has seen my face.

A long beat.

KAILYN

(pebble in her fist)

What happens if we don't?

Marlice looks at her. Just looks at her.

She doesn't answer. She doesn't need to.

BROOKLYN

(long exhale)

What time tonight.

MARLICE

Midnight. She'll be asleep by then.
(MORE)

MARLICE (CONT'D)

She takes something to help her sleep, she has since this started. She knows what's coming she just can't -- she can't do anything about it. So she sleeps.

Brooklyn and Kailyn look at each other.

KAILYN

(quietly)

We're doing this aren't we.

BROOKLYN

(standing up)

Yeah.

She looks across the park at Gus, still writing, still not knowing any of this.

BROOKLYN (CONT'D)

We're doing this.

17 INT. GUS'S HOUSE - CEMENT ROOM - MIDNIGHT

17

Dark. Quiet. The refrigerator hums.

Brooklyn and Kailyn move through the darkness with their phone flashlights. Everything is exactly as they left it. The Post-its. The scorched breaker panel. The amber pulse of the monitor upstairs, faint through the ceiling.

Kailyn opens the refrigerator. Bottom shelf. She scans with her light.

Blue cap.

She takes it. Holds it up. Brooklyn nods.

Then from upstairs -- a THUD.

They freeze.

Footsteps. Slow. Crossing the floor above them.

Then stopping. Right above their heads.

Neither of them breathes.

The footsteps move back. A door closes.

Silence.

BROOKLYN
(mouthing)

Go.

They go.

18 EXT. GUS'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

18

They slip out the back door and into the dark neighborhood. Brooklyn is walking fast. Kailyn is clutching the vial.

KAILYN
(whispering)
Was that her?

BROOKLYN
(whispering)
Yes.

KAILYN
Does she know we were there?

BROOKLYN
I don't know.

KAILYN
Brooklyn.

BROOKLYN
I don't know Kailyn, just walk.

They walk. The street is empty. The houses are all dark.

Kailyn opens her fist. Looks at the vial. Then reaches into her other pocket and takes out the pebble. Holds both.

BROOKLYN (CONT'D)
(glancing over)
You're unbelievable.

KAILYN
(small smile)
It's a rock.

BROOKLYN
It's a pebble.

They keep walking.

19 EXT. PARK - MOMENTS LATER

19

Marlice is waiting exactly where they left her. Like she never moved. She takes the vial, holds it up to the

moonlight, checks it.

Then she exhales. Just slightly. The first time she's looked anything other than certain.

BROOKLYN

Is that enough?

MARLICE

It's enough.

KAILYN

What do you do with it now?

MARLICE

I finish it. I have two days before his temperature drops to the threshold.

BROOKLYN

And then?

MARLICE

And then someone has to give it to him without him knowing.

Brooklyn looks at her.

BROOKLYN

Oh come on.

MARLICE

(almost a smile)

You've done harder things.

BROOKLYN

We really haven't.

Marlice tucks the vial into her jacket. Looks at them both.

MARLICE

Thank you.

It's quiet and direct and it lands. Brooklyn doesn't have anything to say to that.

KAILYN

Your brother. Did he -- is he--

MARLICE

(already walking away)

Two days.

She disappears into the dark.

Brooklyn and Kailyn stand in the empty park.

KAILYN
She didn't answer.

BROOKLYN
No.

A beat.

KAILYN
Do you think Gus knows any of this?

BROOKLYN
(looking at the dark street)
I think he knows something is
wrong. I think he's been knowing.

KAILYN
Should we tell him?

Brooklyn thinks about it for a long time.

BROOKLYN
After. If it works, after.

Kailyn nods. Pockets the pebble.

They walk home in the dark.

20 INT. GUS'S BEDROOM - EARLY MORNING

20

Gus is asleep. Blanket pulled up to his eyes.

On his nightstand, the notebook is open. The last entry:
felt it again today. worse this time. like
something is waiting.

Next to it, a glass of water. Untouched.

Someone has slipped something under his door. A folded
piece of paper. We can't read it from here.

He takes a large breath.

Then goes still.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK

21 EXT. PARK - DAY

21

The same bench. Daytime. A few days later.

GUS sits alone. Notebook closed for once in his lap. Eyes shut, face tilted up slightly. Still. Like he's listening to something no one else can hear.

His breath is normal. No shaking.

He opens his eyes.

He looks around the park slowly, like he's seeing it fresh. Like he's been somewhere else for a while and just got back.

He reaches into his pocket. Takes out a folded piece of paper -- the one from under his door. He looks at it for a long moment.

We still can't read it.

He folds it carefully. Tucks it inside the notebook. Closes the cover.

Then he looks up.

Directly into camera.

Just for a second.

Not scared. Not confused.

He just knows.

CUT TO BLACK.

Credits roll.